

Lecture Points

SOCIAL CONTRACT THEORY

1. Introduction

Social Contract Theory is one of the most important theories explaining the origin of the state. It tells us that the state was not created suddenly, not by God, and not only by force. Instead, it was created by an agreement among people.

In simple words:

- ☞ People agreed to live together under rules.
- ☞ They created a government for safety and order.
- ☞ This agreement is called the **Social Contract**.

The three most famous thinkers of this theory are:

- Thomas Hobbes
- John Locke
- Jean-Jacques Rousseau

All three believed that the state was formed through an agreement, but they had different views about human nature, rights, and government power.

2. Meaning of Social Contract

A **social contract** means:

An agreement among individuals to create a government and obey its laws in return for protection and order.

It is not a written contract like a legal document. It is a theoretical or philosophical idea explaining why we obey the state.

3. State of Nature – The Starting Point

Before forming the state, people lived in what philosophers call the “**State of Nature.**”

State of Nature means:

- No government
- No police
- No courts
- No laws
- Complete freedom

But the thinkers disagreed on what life was like in that condition.

4. Main Features of Social Contract Theory

Here are the key points:

- The state is man-made, not natural or divine.
- People once lived without government.
- Life became unsafe or inconvenient.
- People agreed to give up some freedoms.
- Government was created to protect life and property.
- Political authority is based on consent.
- Government exists for the benefit of people.

5. THOMAS HOBBS (1588–1679)

A. View of Human Nature

Hobbes believed:

- Humans are selfish.
- Humans want power.
- Humans compete with each other.
- Fear and insecurity dominate behavior.

According to him, people naturally fight for survival.

B. State of Nature According to Hobbes

In the state of nature:

- Everyone had unlimited freedom.
- There were no laws.
- There was no authority.
- People fought for power and survival.
- Strong people dominated weak people.

Hobbes described life as:

“Solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short.”

This means life was:

- Lonely
- Dangerous
- Violent
- Short

It was a condition of “**war of all against all.**”

C. Why Social Contract Was Needed

Because life was full of fear and violence, people wanted:

- Security
- Peace
- Protection

So they agreed to create a powerful authority.

D. Nature of Hobbes' Social Contract

- People made an agreement with each other.
- They gave up all their rights to one ruler.
- The ruler became absolute sovereign.

This sovereign could be:

- A king
- An assembly
- Any strong authority

E. Nature of Government

- Government has unlimited power.
- People must obey.
- No right to revolt.
- Even a bad ruler must be obeyed.

Hobbes believed that **any government is better than chaos**.

F. Example

Imagine there are no traffic rules:

- Everyone drives freely.
- Accidents increase.
- People fight.

To avoid this, strict traffic laws are necessary. Hobbes believed society also needs strict authority.

G. Importance of Hobbes

- Explains need for strong state.
- Supports law and order.
- Foundation of modern sovereignty.

H. Criticism of Hobbes

- Supports dictatorship.
- Ignores human rights.

- Assumes humans are always bad.
- Gives unlimited power to ruler.

6. JOHN LOCKE (1632–1704)

A. View of Human Nature

Locke believed:

- Humans are rational.
- Humans can cooperate.
- Humans understand morality.

People are not naturally evil.

B. State of Nature According to Locke

In Locke's state of nature:

- People were free.
- People were equal.
- They had natural rights.

These natural rights include:

1. Right to life
2. Right to liberty
3. Right to property

Life was generally peaceful but not completely safe.

C. Problems in State of Nature

- No clear laws.
- No neutral judge.
- No fixed punishment system.
- Disputes over property.

People needed protection of rights.

D. Nature of Locke's Social Contract

- People formed a government.
- Government power is limited.
- Authority comes from consent of people.

Unlike Hobbes, Locke did NOT support absolute power.

E. Role of Government

Government must:

- Protect life.
- Protect liberty.
- Protect property.
- Make laws with consent.

F. Right to Revolution

Locke strongly believed:

If the government fails to protect rights,

→ People can remove it.

→ People can revolt.

This idea later influenced democratic revolutions.

G. Example

If a government:

- Seizes property illegally,
- Arrests people without reason,
- Violates freedom,

Citizens can protest or change it through elections.

H. Importance of Locke

- Foundation of modern democracy.
- Inspired constitutional government.
- Influenced American and other revolutions.
- Supports limited government.

I. Criticism of Locke

- Too optimistic about human nature.
- Assumes people are always reasonable.
- Property-based theory may increase inequality.

7. JEAN-JACQUES ROUSSEAU (1712–1778)

A. View of Human Nature

Rousseau believed:

- Humans are naturally good.
- Society corrupts humans.
- Inequality began with private property.

B. State of Nature According to Rousseau

In early society:

- People lived simple lives.
- There was no greed.
- There was no competition.
- Life was peaceful.

But as society developed:

- Property created inequality.
- Rich dominated poor.
- Corruption increased.

C. Nature of Social Contract

Rousseau said:

People surrender their personal will to the **General Will**.

General Will means:

- ✍ What is best for society as a whole.
- ✍ Collective interest.

D. Popular Sovereignty

- Power belongs to people.
- Government is only representative.
- People are the real sovereign.

E. Example

When a country provides:

- Free education
- Public healthcare
- Welfare programs

It reflects general will for public good.

F. Importance of Rousseau

- Supports equality.
- Promotes popular sovereignty.
- Inspired French Revolution.
- Strengthens idea of participatory democracy.

G. Criticism of Rousseau

- General will is unclear.
- May lead to majority tyranny.
- Can suppress minority rights.

8. Comparison of Hobbes, Locke, and Rousseau

Basis	Hobbes	Locke	Rousseau
Human Nature	Selfish	Rational	Naturally good
State of Nature	Violent	Mostly peaceful	Simple and happy
Rights	Given up completely	Protected	Combined in general will
Government	Absolute	Limited	Based on popular sovereignty
Right to Revolt	No	Yes	Yes

9. Overall Importance of Social Contract Theory

This theory is important because:

- Explains origin of state logically.
- Supports democracy.
- Emphasizes consent.
- Promotes human rights.
- Encourages accountability.
- Basis of constitutional government.

Modern constitutions are influenced by these ideas.

10. Relevance in Modern Times

Today:

- Governments derive power from people.
- Elections show consent.
- Citizens have rights.
- Rule of law exists.

These ideas come from Social Contract thinkers.

Even today, when governments fail, people protest. This shows social contract is still relevant.

11. General Criticism of Social Contract Theory

- No historical proof of actual contract.
- State of nature is imaginary.
- Based on assumptions.
- Oversimplifies origin of state.

However, it remains very influential.

12. Conclusion

Social Contract Theory explains that the state was formed by agreement among individuals for safety, order, and protection of rights.

- Hobbes emphasized security and strong authority.
- Locke emphasized rights and limited government.
- Rousseau emphasized equality and popular sovereignty.

Together, their ideas form the foundation of modern political systems, democracy, and constitutional governance.

THEORIES OF STATE (GENERAL)

1. Introduction – Understanding the State

Before studying the theories, we must clearly understand what a state is.

A state is a political organization that has four basic elements:

1. **Population** – People who live in a particular area.
2. **Territory** – A fixed geographical area with clear boundaries.
3. **Government** – An authority that makes and enforces laws.
4. **Sovereignty** – Supreme power to make decisions without external control.

Without these four elements, a state cannot exist.

Why Do We Study Theories of the State?

Since ancient times, thinkers have tried to answer questions like:

- How did the state begin?
- Was it created suddenly or gradually?
- Why do people obey rulers?
- Is authority based on religion, force, or consent?
- Does the state serve the people or control them?

Different thinkers gave different explanations. These explanations are called **Theories of the State**.

Each theory focuses on one major factor:

- Religion
- Force
- Family
- Gradual development
- Economic class
- Public welfare

No single theory gives a complete answer, but together they help us understand how modern states developed.

1. Divine Theory of the State

Main Thinkers

- St. Augustine
- Thomas Aquinas
- James I of England

Main Idea

The state is created by **God**.

The ruler is chosen by God.

People must obey the ruler as a **religious obligation**.

This theory was very popular in medieval times when religion strongly influenced politics.

Step-by-Step Explanation

1. God created the world.
2. God created human society.
3. To maintain order, God appointed rulers.
4. The king rules in the name of God.
5. Therefore, disobeying the king is equal to disobeying God.

This idea is also known as the Divine Right of Kings.

Why Was This Theory Important?

In early societies:

- People were deeply religious.
- Religion shaped their thinking.
- There was no concept of democracy.
- Kings needed justification for their power.

This theory gave moral and religious legitimacy to rulers.

Example

In medieval Europe, kings declared:

“I am God’s representative on Earth.”

Similarly, many ancient rulers in different civilizations believed they were divinely chosen.

Advantages

- Created unity in society.
- Reduced rebellion.
- Maintained stability.
- Strengthened respect for authority.

Criticism

- No scientific or historical proof.
- Encouraged absolute monarchy.
- Ignored rights of people.
- Opposed democratic ideas.
- Cannot explain modern constitutional states.

Today, this theory is mostly rejected in democratic countries.

2. Force Theory of the State

Main Thinkers

- Eugen Dühring
- Ludwig Gumplowicz
- Franz Oppenheimer

Main Idea

The state was created by **force and conquest**.

Strong individuals or tribes defeated weaker ones and established control.

Political power came from military strength.

Step-by-Step Explanation

1. Early humans lived in tribes.
2. Tribes competed for land, water, and resources.
3. Strong tribes attacked weaker tribes.
4. After victory, they imposed their authority.
5. The conquered people were forced to obey.
6. Over time, this organized control became a state.

So according to this theory:

“**Might is right.**”

Example

The Roman Empire expanded its territory through war and conquest.

Many ancient empires like Mongol and Ottoman empires were formed by military power.

Importance

- Explains role of war in history.
- Realistic about human conflict.
- Shows how early empires were built.
- Highlights importance of military strength.

Criticism

- Ignores peaceful cooperation.
- Cannot explain modern democratic states.
- Force alone cannot create loyalty.
- Long-term stability requires consent, not only fear.

Force may create a state, but it cannot maintain it forever.

3. Patriarchal Theory of the State

Main Thinkers

- Aristotle
- Henry Maine

Main Idea

The state developed from the **family system**.

The authority of the father gradually expanded into political authority.

Step-by-Step Development

1. The family was the first social group.
2. Father was head of the family.
3. Many families formed a clan.
4. Clans formed tribes.
5. Tribes formed villages and towns.
6. Eventually, organized political authority developed.

Thus, the state grew naturally from family relationships.

Why Was This Idea Logical?

In early societies:

- Family was the main unit.
- Leadership was based on age and lineage.
- Respect for elders was strong.

So political authority was similar to parental authority.

Example

In tribal communities, leadership is often hereditary.

Village elders or chiefs rule based on family status.

Importance

- Emphasizes importance of family.
- Explains natural growth of authority.
- Connects social organization with political organization.

Criticism

- State is more complex than family.
- Modern states include millions of unrelated citizens.
- Political authority is legal, not emotional like family authority.
- Cannot explain constitutional democracy.

4. Evolutionary Theory of the State

Main Thinkers

- Herbert Spencer
- Edward Jenks

Main Idea

The state developed gradually over time.

It was not created suddenly by one event.

It evolved due to:

- Social needs
- Economic changes
- Religion
- Customs
- War
- Population growth

Step-by-Step Explanation

1. Humans lived in small groups.
2. Groups developed customs and traditions.
3. Leaders emerged to solve disputes.
4. Rules became formal laws.
5. Administrative systems developed.

6. Gradually, the modern state appeared.

This theory compares state development to biological evolution.

Why Is It Considered Scientific?

- It accepts multiple causes.
- It is supported by historical evidence.
- It explains slow and gradual development.

Example

As agriculture developed:

- People settled permanently.
- Property ownership emerged.
- Need for protection increased.
- Government institutions formed.

Importance

- Most widely accepted theory.
- Realistic explanation.
- Explains complexity of modern state.

Criticism

- Does not explain exact starting point.
- Too general.
- Lacks specific stages.

5. Marxist Theory of the State

Main Thinkers

- Karl Marx
- Friedrich Engels

Main Idea

The state is a tool of the **rich class**.

It protects the interests of property owners.

Society is divided into classes:

- Bourgeoisie (capitalists)
- Proletariat (workers)

Step-by-Step Explanation

1. Private property developed.
2. Economic inequality increased.
3. Rich class gained control of production.
4. State was formed to protect property.
5. Laws favored the rich.
6. Workers were exploited.

According to Marx:

The state is an instrument of class domination.

Example

In capitalist countries:

- Corporations influence policies.
- Labor laws sometimes favor businesses.
- Economic inequality continues.

Future Prediction

Marx believed:

- Workers would revolt.
- Classless society would emerge.
- The state would disappear.

This stage is called communism.

Importance

- Highlights economic inequality.
- Explains class conflict.
- Influenced socialist movements.
- Encouraged labor rights.

Criticism

- Overemphasizes economic factor.
- Modern states provide welfare.
- State has not disappeared anywhere.
- Ignores political and cultural factors.

6. Welfare State Theory

Main Thinkers

- T. H. Marshall
- John Maynard Keynes
- Harold Laski

Main Idea

The state exists to promote the welfare of people.

It should not only maintain law and order but also improve quality of life.

Key Functions of Welfare State

- Provide education.
- Provide healthcare.
- Reduce unemployment.
- Reduce poverty.
- Provide social security.
- Ensure economic stability.

Step-by-Step Role

1. Government collects taxes.
2. Uses money for public services.
3. Supports poor and vulnerable.
4. Promotes equality.
5. Ensures social justice.

Example

Government programs such as:

- Public hospitals
- Scholarships
- Pensions
- Food subsidies
- Unemployment benefits

Importance

- Promotes social justice.
- Reduces inequality.
- Protects weaker sections.
- Improves living standards.

Criticism

- High taxes.
- Financial burden.
- Bureaucratic inefficiency.
- Risk of dependency.

Comparison of Major Theories

Theory	Main Basis	View of Authority
Divine	God	Absolute
Force	War	Military power
Patriarchal	Family	Paternal
Evolutionary	Gradual growth	Institutional
Marxist	Class domination	Economic control
Welfare	Social justice	Service-oriented

Overall Importance of Theories of State

These theories help us:

- Understand origin of political authority.
- Analyze political systems.
- Compare historical and modern states.
- Study development of democracy.
- Understand relationship between state and society.

Modern states are influenced by multiple factors:

- Force (security)
- Evolution (development)
- Economy (resources)
- Welfare (public good)
- Consent (democracy)

Final Conclusion

Theories of the State give different explanations about how the state originated and why it exists.

- Divine Theory emphasizes religion.
- Force Theory emphasizes power.
- Patriarchal Theory emphasizes family.
- Evolutionary Theory emphasizes gradual development.
- Marxist Theory emphasizes class struggle.
- Welfare Theory emphasizes social justice.

No single theory fully explains the origin of the state, but together they provide a complete understanding of how modern political systems developed.